

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

‘People are still fighting for them’

Gift drive for those affected by immigration crackdown raises more than \$10,000

By Laura Turbay
Chicago Tribune

William McNiff has been a vocal critic of the recent immigration crackdown in Chicago on his TikTok profile. So when he heard about the Salvation Army’s Angel Tree program, which provides gifts for children and families in need, he wondered if he could do something similar for children of immigrant families affected by Operation Midway Blitz in the city.

In less than a week, McNiff and his friend Taylor Krahl raised over \$10,000 on their GoFundMe page to buy gifts and groceries for families in the Chicago area. McNiff helped spread the word about the project on his TikTok account, which has over 41,000 followers.

The gift haul was coined Operation Midway Bliss as a way to reclaim the name from the federal government’s Operation Midway Blitz, which wreaked havoc on the city’s immigrant community.

“When I saw those Angel Trees blowing up (on social media),” said McNiff, who lives in the Gold Coast, “an idea sparked of something I can do for my neighbors here in Chicago, aside from just yapping on TikTok or going to a protest, something that can actually have an impact directly.”

The pair is working with Organización Hijos de Migrantes to distribute a gift and an essential item, such as a coat, to about 170 children from 100 families impacted by immigration enforcement in the Chicago area and Aurora that were selected on a first-come, first-served basis, according to Sheila Jara, the organization’s founder. The gifts and items, which are chosen from an Amazon Wish List based on the families’ interests, are scheduled to be shipped out to children up to age 18 starting soon.

In addition to the gifts, each family will receive about \$50 worth of groceries from tortillas to toilet paper delivered right to their doorstep, since many still do not want to leave their homes for fear of being detained, according to Jara.

“The great part about Operation Midway Bliss is that we will have personalized bags of items that we know families will need,” Jara said.

When Krahl, who met McNiff through TikTok last year, heard about his gift-giving plan, she immediately jumped on board. “I went into crazy business owner logistic mode,” said Krahl, who co-runs her own pool business in Naperville and

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BRUCE DOLD 1955-2025



E. JASON WAMBSGANS/TRIBUNE

A ‘consummate newspaperman’

Bruce Dold, who rose from suburban reporter to editor and publisher during his prodigious four-decade career at the Chicago Tribune, had only a handful of bylines after his name took its place on the masthead. But the Pulitzer Prize-winning journalist who died Wednesday at age 70 left an indelible mark on the newspaper and the city, tackling the issues of the day, promoting civil discourse and influencing public policy. **Chicagoland, Page 2**

One man’s path from border crosser to accused killer illustrates the real-life consequences and exploitation of ever-shifting federal immigration priorities

When an execution killing becomes political theater



Cook County Jail booking photos of Jose Coronado Meza starting on July 3, 2024, from left, then again on Dec. 14, 2024, Jan. 5 and last on July 7, after he was accused of shoplifting twice, then arrested twice more for alleged illegal gun possession. **COOK COUNTY SHERIFF’S OFFICE**

By Joe Mahr and Gregory Royal Pratt
Chicago Tribune

For one day in September, Jose Coronado Meza became the Trump administration’s poster child for why Chicago needed to be flooded with federal agents.

Coronado Meza had been ordered deported. But the Biden administration let him live in Chicago, where he got arrested for murder. Democrats’ “sanctuary” ways had coddled a would-be killer. Or so the argument went.

But a deeper look at the case offers a window into the erratic nature of immi-

gration enforcement — even in eras when administrations tout crackdowns. The case shows how someone like Coronado Meza can slip through the cracks of both Democratic and Republican administrations, once the facts get separated from the bluster and politics.

Democratic policies for sure helped him stay on the streets despite a string of arrests, the Tribune found, such as ignoring a formal request to hold him for immigration agents.

But so did choices made by the Trump administration in its first five months

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WAITING FOR THE SHIPS TO COME IN?

Federal funding cuts threaten around-the-clock operation of Chicago Harbor Lock, one of the nation’s busiest passageways for both commercial and recreational use

By Talia Soglin | Chicago Tribune

The Linnea pulled off her dock on the north side of the Chicago River.

Sailing underneath burgundy bridges, the vessel glided east toward the lake. On that October afternoon, Trump Tower receded in the distance. Ten minutes later, the Linnea — a commercial tour boat operated by Wendella Tours & Cruises — arrived at the Chicago Harbor Lock, the mechanism through which boats in Chicago must travel to sail between the river and Lake Michigan.

The harbor lock is one of the nation’s busiest for both commercial and recreational use; more than 900,000 passengers and 80,000 vessels traveled through it last year. But looming federal funding cuts have become a source of worry for boaters who rely on the lock.

The U.S. Army Corps of Engineers operates the harbor lock. It functions like a water elevator, allowing vessels to travel the different elevation levels between Lake Michigan and the Chicago River, the latter of which is typically kept several feet lower than the lake, a result of the feat of engineering that saw the flow of the Chicago River reversed in 1900.

The Army Corps requested \$3.85 million for the operation and maintenance of the Chicago Harbor Lock and Dam next year, Corps spokesperson Emily Helton said. But in his proposed fiscal year 2026 budget, President Donald Trump allocated under \$300,000 for the harbor, leaving a shortfall of more than \$3.5 million, Helton said.

In order to try to close the gap, Helton said, the Army Corps will use just over \$1 million in leftover operating funds from this year. It will also reallocate some money it had previously planned to use

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Top: A boat passes through Chicago Harbor Lock at the connection of the Chicago River and Lake Michigan on Oct. 1. **Above:** Water flows from Lake Michigan into the lock as the gates open. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS**